oppose attempts by the incumbent powers to use their financial market leverage to further their political goals. This case involves each of the other four countries deciding to support Russia's efforts to resist U.S. and EU financial sanctions that followed Russia's 2014 intervention in Eastern Ukraine beginning in February, subsequent annexation of Crimea, and ongoing support of separatists in Eastern Ukraine.

Economic and other forms of targeted sanctions have been sequentially deployed by the United States and the EU to change Russia's international behavior by imposing costs that escalate over the medium term.[79] Rather than bring Russia's economy to its knees by targeting the Russian sovereign, U.S. sanctions have been designed to demonstrate a sustainable and scalable ability to generate overwhelming costs while avoiding unwanted spillover effects, such as disruptions to global financial markets or provoking the Kremlin to shut off gas supplies to Europe. The Obama administration believed that sanctions affect Putin's calculus (viewing him as risk-acceptant and revisionist) and deterred Russian escalation of the war, while also giving Ukraine time to reform its military and economy. The product of Euro-Atlantic political compromises, the sanctions were considered a second-best option by many U.S. policymakers who favor arming Ukraine. They indirectly led to a more hybrid war and were not always well sequenced. In fact, some sanctions were increased during the first ceasefire agreement and exchange of prisoners, while others failed to affect an expansion of the territory under the separatists' control, including the Donetsk airport and the city of Debaltseve.

Given that the West remains unwilling to use military force to defend Ukraine, sanctions are the principal instrument available to coerce and constrain, and also to send a costly signal to the Kremlin that the West deems Russia's international behavior unacceptable and might be willing to raise the costs. After the Russian annexation of Crimea in March 2014, Washington moved quickly to speed sanctions into effect, attempting to save Ukraine from a deteriorating situation. Together with a 50 percent plunge in the price of oil and a correlated collapse of the ruble since mid-June 2014, the sanctions had a negative economic impact on the Russian economy, but without notable political success for the West. This result is in line with leading studies of sanctions showing that they work in less than 30 percent of cases in terms of achieving desired policy shifts.[80] Targeted financial sanctions can cause significant punishment, and brought about concessions that may have helped delay Iran's nuclear ambitions, for instance. Sanctions